narrowed his eyes behind his big, square spectacles. He was reading something scribbled in his diary. Both of them had been busy since late afternoon, calculating our monthly finances. The setting sun had brought in a golden radiance inside the living room of our row house in the Jabalpur Officers Married Accommodation colony. Fresh evening breeze drafted in from the open windows. It was a relief as the morning drizzle had left the afternoon hot and humid. I could see Maa's worried grimace from the corner of the room, where I was playing with Beauty, our snow-white Pomeranian. Whether the grimace was induced by the disheartening headline or the figures on the calculator, I could not tell. I turned my attention back to Beauty, who kept trying to climb on to my shoulders to play with the ribbons in my plaits.

'Something doesn't add up,' a worried Maa mumbled as she rechecked the calculations. 'There's hardly any savings for this month.' She paused to lower her voice and then whispered, 'And Gunjan's birthday is next month.' I could hear them from where I was sitting.

'I asked you to let me opt for a field posting,' Papaji said in a dispirited tone, still studying the balance sheet in his diary. 'The allowance money that officers are given to serve in high altitudes and tough terrain would have helped.'

'Anshu and Gunju couldn't have lived without you,' Maa said. 'You know how restless and fidgety they get when you leave for even a couple of weeks of temporary duty or exercises.'

'But at least they could have continued to study in St Mary's,' Papaji replied, resting the pen and looking away from his diary. I looked away before Maa could steal a glance at me. Reassured that I wasn't prying on them, she said, 'Kendriya Vidyalaya is equally good. The staff is qualified, and its curriculum is promising. I wouldn't have taken this decision without thinking it through. And the best part is that they can both just cycle and go. No expenses for a school bus.' Maa had gotten Dada and me shifted to Kendriya Vidyalaya before the academic session for my fourth standard and Dada's fifth. Instead of lying to us, Maa had plainly told us that it was getting difficult for them to afford St Mary's. It was not in her nature to hide